

Collaborator or Assistant?

How AI Coding Agents Partition Work Across Pull Request Lifecycles

An agent's work can surface under a human identity; the trace measures visibility, not authorship.

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STEP 1 The instrument: PRs as traces

The talk gave the map; the poster uses it to read visibility and review.

1 Each PR is a lifecycle

A sequence of events, not just a row in a table.

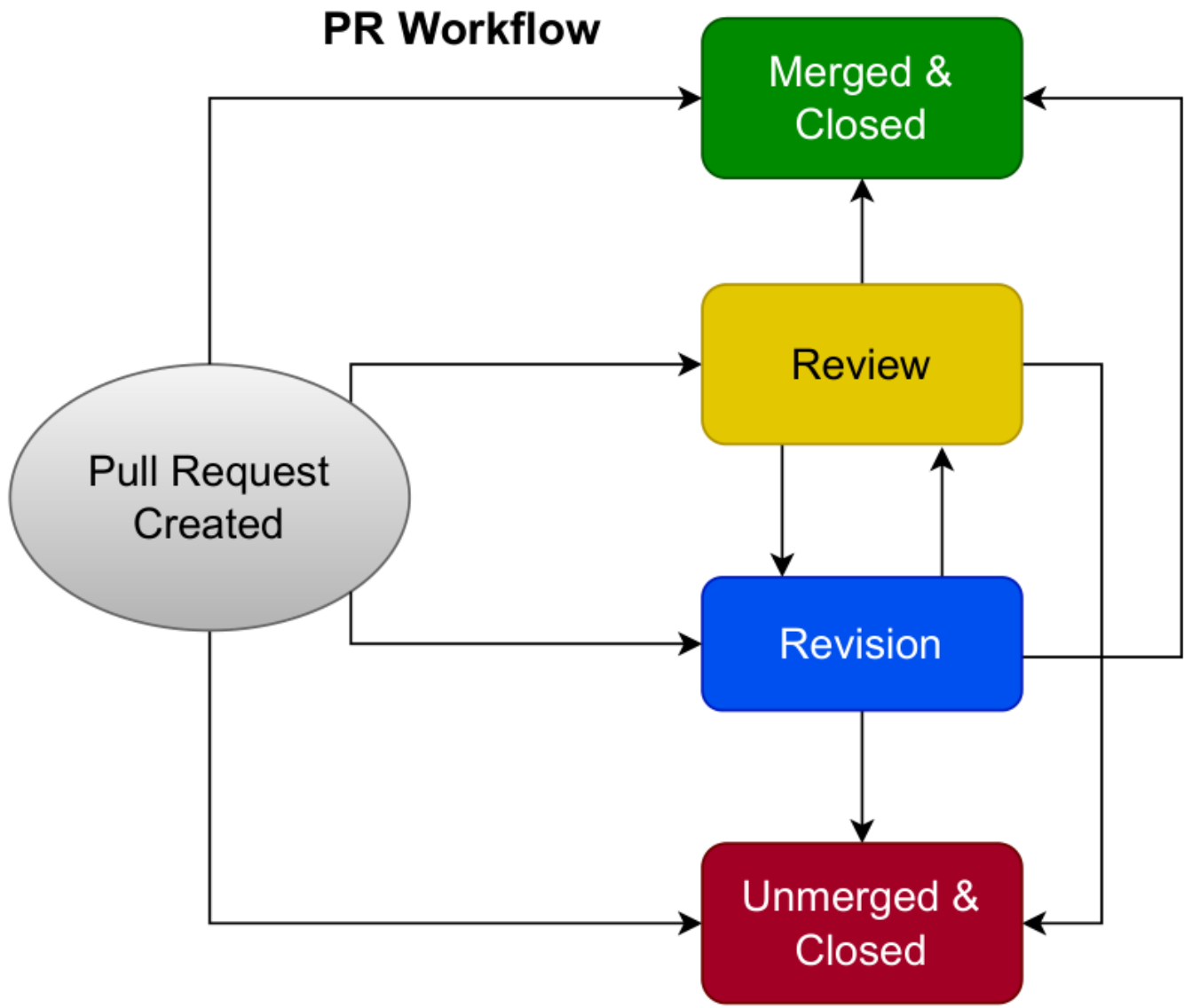
2 The map separates roles

First commit, review, and merge are distinct trace surfaces.

3 Initiator = first committer

It records who the commit is logged under — an attribution surface.

That surface is visible identity, not verified authorship.
This is the gap the poster follows.

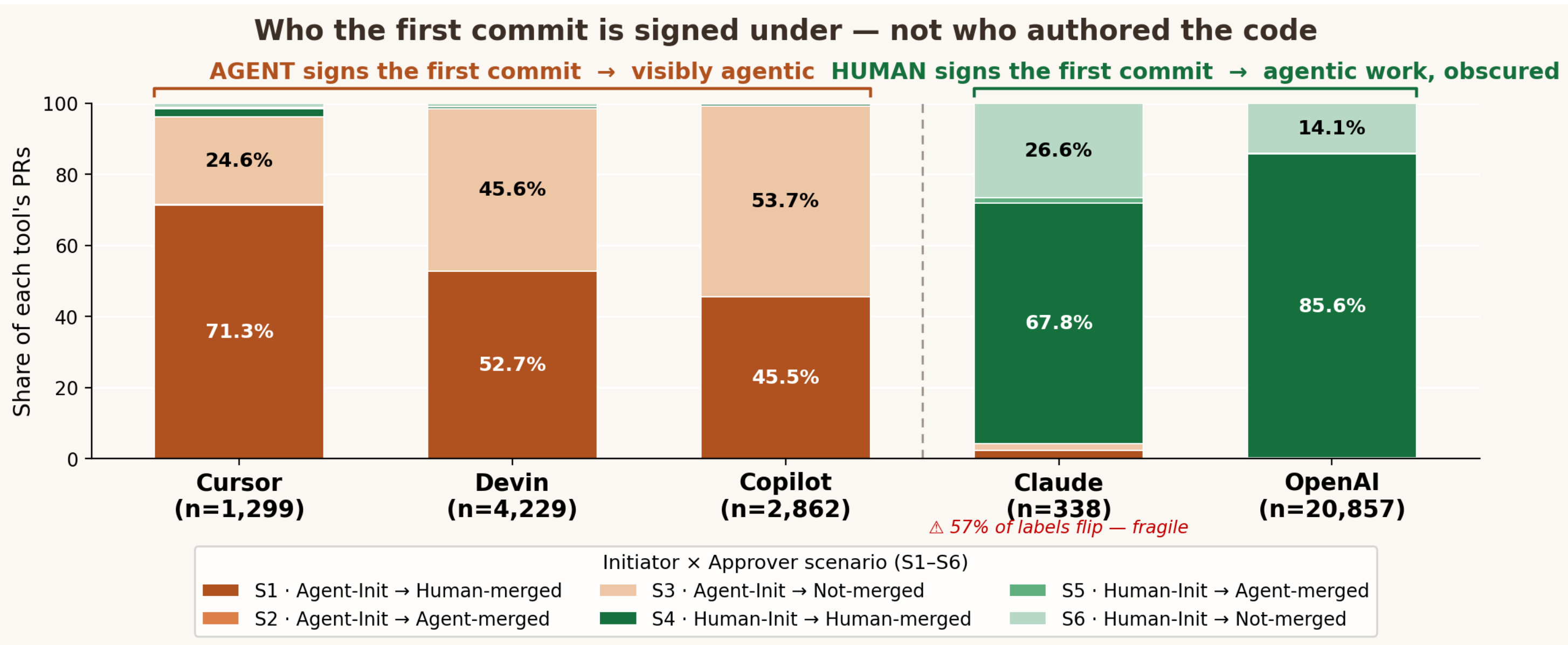


Why a state machine?

Because the question is not only whether a PR merged. It is what path it took: who appears first, whether review appears, and who executes the merge.

STEP 2 Figure 3 changes meaning: visibility, not workforce

Same six scenarios, corrected lens: the bars show how agentic work surfaces in the trace.



How to read it

Warm bars: the agent/bot is visible at first commit. Green bars: the first commit surfaces under a human account. In this agentic corpus, green does not mean human-authored; it means agent work is less visible.

Codex carries the pattern (n=20,857, ~99.9% human-signed); Claude is consistent but fragile — n=338 and 57% of its labels flip under attribution-aware re-detection.

STEP 3 Visibility meets review

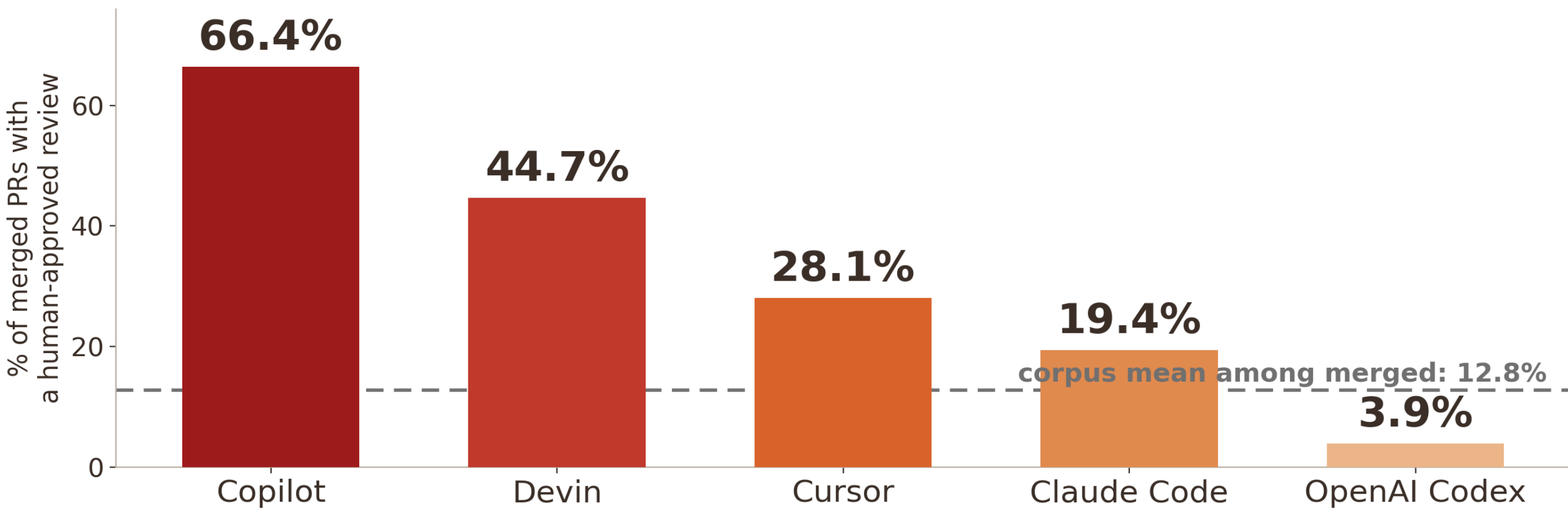
One association to remember: the least visible agentic work has the least recorded human-approved review.

89.6%

of 29,585 terminal PRs have no recorded human-approved review. Among merged PRs, only 12.8% show one.

17×

spread in human-approved review: Copilot 66.4% to OpenAI Codex 3.9%.



The poster's claim: the lifecycle map still works, but Figure 3 should be read as attribution visibility. Once read that way, the same traces expose a governance gap: human review is sparse overall and lowest where agentic work is least visible as agentic. Association, not cause.

Collaborator or Assistant? A junior teammate — often under your name.

The puzzle: AI work can enter a repository under a human name. **The trace:** most merges still look human-governed. **The gap:** recorded human-approved review is often absent. **The question:** what should repositories log if they want to govern agent-generated change?